stood on the issue. The British were there for reasons of strategic self-interest. They were not there to nation-build or encourage gender reform. ‘There is nothing more to be dreaded or guarded against’, he wrote, ‘than the overweening confidence with which we are too often accustomed to regard the excellence of our own institutions, and the anxiety that we display to introduce them in new and untried soils. Such interference will always lead to acrimonious disputes, if not to a violent reaction.’[79]

Meanwhile, Wade’s spies in Kabul were reporting that Dost Mohammad was living up to his reputation for efficiency and had been energetically preparing for the British advance by building up his army and repairing the fortifications of Ghazni. He sent a mass of stores down the Kabul River to Jalalabad, and procured a fatwa of jihad against Shah Shuja from the ‘ulema of Kabul. He also wrote to Teheran to try to persuade Mohammad Shah to return to the field of battle, ‘urging his Majesty to assist him without delay’ and declaring that this was now the last opportunity he had before the British established themselves in Afghanistan. ‘The mouth of a fountain may in the beginning be stopped by a needle,’ he wrote, ‘but when it overflows even the elephant has not the power to arrest its course.’[80] Intelligence of all this activity reached the British camp around 20 June and it was decided that the quicker Dost Mohammad was attacked the better.

The 200-mile march from Kandahar to Ghazni initially took the troops through the rich and fertile Arghandab Valley, with its brown waters and silvery willows, its mud-walled orchards of pomegranates and vines and deep red mulberries lining the irrigation ditches. But beyond that, the further the troops marched from the banks of the Arghandab and the network of bubbling irrigation runnels which extended the cultivation to the melon beds at the edge of the valley, the drier the land became. White grasslands blowing in the wind around Qalat e-Ghilzai slowly gave way to a rockier, hillier, more marginal landscape of quartz and shale-scrub, dotted with white opium poppies and purple thistles. The army was now passing into the territories of the Ghilzais: it was barren, ‘wild and mountainous country’, wrote William Taylor,

> over roads extremely difficult and at times almost impassable. The Ghilzies fled at our approach to the numerous mud forts with which these hills abound, and seldom ventured on our track. In the dwellings they had abandoned we found only a few old crones and hungry dogs, both of whom received us with a sort of howling welcome . . . We were lucky enough to discover the stores of corn and *bussorah* [fodder] which the natives had buried at the first news of our